

INTERNATIONAL MANAGERS / US WORKPLACES

Cross-Cultural Leadership English

Clear language for decisive, respectful leadership.



Eight real-work situations.
Eight extended conversations.
One practical learner's book.

INSIDE THE BOOK

96 vocabulary entries / 64 reusable phrases
160 dialogue turns / 80 numbered dialogue gaps
Word banks, precise instructions, and full answer support

Upper-intermediate to advanced (B2-C1). For international managers, cross-border teams, and workplace English learners.

Approval draft 01 | 30 September 2026 | Review copy. Existing online downloads unchanged.

Eight scenarios. Eight skills.

The lesson numbers match the website. Within each lesson, circled A-F labels separate the activities from the main lesson number.

01 Check meaning before assuming agreement

5

When "fine" is not a green light | Clarify scope, distinguish acknowledgment from approval, and confirm conditions.

02 Challenge ideas respectfully

12

A sharp objection at the budget review | Probe evidence, make a concession without surrendering the decision, and set a conduct boundary.

03 Make authority and participation clear

19

Delegating without disappearing | Define decision rights, invite recommendations, and delegate within explicit limits.

04 Negotiate realistic commitments

26

Friday estimates or Monday verified figures | Offer bounded alternatives, use conditional commitments, and distinguish a forecast from a promise.

05 Include every voice in a meeting

33

The remote question nobody heard | Manage turn-taking, interrupt constructively, paraphrase accurately, and close a hybrid meeting.

06 Give specific, useful feedback

40

Two late reports and one missing handoff | Describe behavior, explain operational impact, ask about causes, and agree a measurable next step.

07 Coordinate across offices

47

One report, two different purposes | Negotiate a reporting interface, translate local constraints, and define exceptions without weakening oversight.

08 Repair misunderstandings and build trust

54

An apology that changes the next meeting | Acknowledge a specific impact, separate intent from effect, repair the record, and agree a verifiable change.

Using this book

3

Directness, disagreement, and boundaries

4

Answer explanations

61

Fast-access phrase pages

69

Vocabulary index

71

Sources and publication notes

75

Use the book, not a blank page.

Every task supplies the facts and the language choices. There are no essays, invented business decisions, or unbounded "think about it" prompts.

- A Read the situation.** Read the briefing and fixed facts. Circle one answer for each of the three checks.
- B Find the words.** Read each term, its meaning, and its typical word combination. Say the combination aloud once.
- C Notice the language.** Read eight usable phrases and three precise language notes. Keep the intended certainty and authority.
- D Check your understanding.** Select one best answer for each of four language checks. The back-of-book explanations identify the deciding detail.
- E Conversations.** Complete one 20-turn dialogue using its ten-entry word-and-phrase bank. Use each entry once, without changing its form. Small raised numbers identify the gaps. Cover the answer strip at the end until finished.
- F Say it.** Complete a short transfer conversation using a four-entry bank. Then follow the printed read-aloud sequence; use the supplied words and facts, not invented replies.

A CLOZE EXAMPLE

Bank: pending / approved

"Has the review finished?" "No. Approval is 1 _____."

Answer: 1 pending. The unfinished review rules out "approved."

Pace and checking

Full route: allow 75-90 minutes per lesson. Short route: spend 25 minutes on B, E, and F. Check A and D at the back; E and F answers appear beneath their dialogues. Read any corrected line aloud before repeating the exchange.

B2-C1 is an intended study range, not a certified assessment. Use the vocabulary pages as support; for a harder repeat, cover the bank but keep the facts visible. All characters, organizations, figures, and conversations are fictional.

Direct is not the same as hostile.

A colleague can strongly challenge an idea without disliking its author. A friendly manner can also hide a real objection. Words, follow-up behavior, power, and context matter more than nationality. Ask what a statement means before deciding what the speaker intended.

THE PRACTICAL DISTINCTION

Accept a testable challenge. Clarify an ambiguous message. Set a boundary around personal contempt, threats, or repeated interruption. You do not need to infer a hidden motive to name an observable problem.

Strong task disagreement

"I do not buy that estimate. The trial took twice as long."

Ask: "Which part of the trial is comparable, and what estimate does it support?"

Ambiguous assent

"Fine. Let us move on."

Check: "Does that approve the date, or only the approach? What remains conditional?"

Personal disrespect

"You clearly do not understand your job."

Set a limit: "Please address the evidence, not my competence. Which claim are you disputing?"

Threat or intimidation

"You will regret raising this."

Pause the exchange if needed. Use the appropriate workplace reporting or support route. An English exercise is not a substitute for a safety or conduct process.

Check the local norm explicitly

First names do not remove decision authority. An invitation to debate is not a transfer of approval rights. Silence does not establish consent. "I will try" does not specify a deliverable. A private conversation does not remove the need for an accurate shared decision record.

Communication practice, not a national personality guide: individuals and organizations vary. Psychological-safety research concerns whether teams can take interpersonal risks, such as asking questions; it does not require the absence of disagreement [3]. Language activities draw on interaction and mediation themes in the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages (CEFR) [1].

When "fine" is not a green light

A Read the situation

Clarify scope, distinguish acknowledgment from approval, and confirm conditions.

Aiko recorded agreement to a Monday product launch after hearing that the plan was "fine." Jordan then sent a staffing concern. The branch has six trained people; the launch plan needs eight. Two more people may finish training on Friday, but completion is not yet confirmed. Aiko can authorize the branch launch after the staffing check.

PEOPLE / Aiko: International branch manager | Jordan: US-based operations lead

ACKNOWLEDGMENT IS NOT AUTHORIZATION

A nod, "fine," or "I see" can acknowledge a message without approving the proposed action. This ambiguity is not unique to any nationality. A manager who hears agreement can check it without embarrassing the speaker: identify the precise decision, name any condition, and read back the record. Do not ask whether the colleague is "really committed" when the unresolved issue is staffing.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use only the briefing. Explanations: page 61.

1. Which point is confirmed before the conversation?

- | | |
|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| A Eight people are trained. | B Six people are trained. |
| C Monday has been approved. | D Friday training is complete. |

2. Who can authorize the branch launch after the check?

- | | |
|-----------------------|-----------------------------------|
| A Jordan alone | B Either trainee |
| C Aiko | D Nobody named in the case |

3. What needs clarification?

- | | |
|--|---|
| A Whether "fine" approved the date or only the general plan | B Whether Monday is a weekday |
| C Whether Jordan received the email | D Whether the product has a name |

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words

Read the meaning, then say the word combination aloud. The combinations show how the term naturally fits into workplace language.

acknowledgment

A signal that a message has been received or understood.

IN USE acknowledge receipt

endorsement

An expression of support for a proposal or position.

IN USE endorse a proposal

authorization

Permission from someone entitled to approve an action.

IN USE obtain authorization

reservation

A concern that limits or qualifies support.

IN USE express a reservation

provisional

Not final; subject to a stated check or decision.

IN USE provisional launch date

dependency

Something that must happen for another action to proceed.

IN USE resolve a dependency

read-back

A spoken restatement used to check the shared record.

IN USE give a read-back

sign-off

A formal or agreed approval step.

IN USE get final sign-off

scope

The limits of what a statement or agreement covers.

IN USE clarify the scope

conditional agreement

Support that applies only if a requirement is met.

IN USE record conditional agreement

go/no-go decision

A decision to proceed or stop at a defined checkpoint.

IN USE make a go/no-go decision

green light

Informal permission to proceed, not merely positive feedback.

IN USE give the green light

Precision check

Acknowledgment confirms that a message was received or understood. Endorsement expresses support. Authorization permits action. Ask which of these the speaker is giving; do not record one as another.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language

Read each complete phrase. The small label names its job in the conversation; the wording remains professional without hiding the point.

SPECIFY THE REFERENCE

"When you say "fine," are you referring to the date or the overall approach?"

SEPARATE TWO MEANINGS

"I heard support for the approach, not approval of the date."

STATE THE CONDITION

"My support is conditional on having eight trained people."

CHECK A COMMITMENT

"Can I record that as a commitment, or is it still a possibility?"

PRESERVE UNCERTAINTY

"That remains provisional until we complete the staffing check."

MAKE AN INDIRECT QUESTION

"Could you confirm whether the additional training is complete?"

READ BACK THE AGREEMENT

"Let me read that back so we have the same decision record."

CLOSE THE LOOP

"I will send the revised record and ask you to confirm it."

Embedded questions

Use "Could you confirm whether the training is complete?" The clause after "whether" has statement order, not "whether is the training complete."

Meaning of "not yet"

"Not yet approved" leaves approval open. "Not approved" can sound like a refusal unless the context makes the pending status clear.

Precision before politeness

"Are we aligned?" is broad. "Are you approving Monday, provided that eight people are trained?" checks an action and its condition.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Choose the question that checks authorization, not receipt.

- A Did you see the revised plan?
- B Did the plan reach your inbox?
- C Have you authorized the Monday launch?
- D Would you like a shorter copy?

2. Complete: "Could you clarify whether ___?"

- A is the date final
- B the date is final
- C does the date final
- D the date final is it

3. Choose the record supported by the briefing.

- A Eight staff confirmed; Monday approved.
- B No staffing concerns were raised.
- C Jordan has canceled the product.
- D Monday is provisional pending a staffing check.

4. Which collocation means to settle an outstanding requirement?

- A resolve a dependency
- B receive a deadline
- C endorse a receipt
- D authorize a reservation

CHECK, CORRECT, REPEAT

Check the explanations on page 61. For each error, read the complete corrected message aloud once. Then reread the relevant phrase on page 7. All four checks must be corrected before you continue.



When "fine" is not a green light

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. The small raised number identifies the gap, not the turn. Cover the answer strip on the next page.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

acknowledgment / unconfirmed / authorization / green light / still provisional / flag / read-back / conditional / reservation / certify

- 01 **Aiko:** Thanks for coming back to this. I recorded Monday as agreed after you said the plan was fine. Your email mentions staffing, so I may have captured the wrong decision.
- 02 **Jordan:** You did. I was comfortable with the sequence, but I was not giving the ¹ _____ for Monday. We still have two people waiting to finish training.
- 03 **Aiko:** All right. When you said "fine," did you mean the sequence was workable, while the date still depended on the training?
- 04 **Jordan:** Exactly. My support was ² _____. Six people are trained now; we need eight. I should have stated the condition in the meeting.
- 05 **Aiko:** That helps. I also moved too quickly from a positive comment to a decision. Have the two remaining people completed the final assessment?
- 06 **Jordan:** Not yet. Friday is the scheduled assessment, not a confirmed completion date. Until the results are in, the extra capacity is ³ _____.
- 07 **Aiko:** Then I will correct the record. We support the launch sequence, but Monday is not authorized. Is there another constraint that I have missed?
- 08 **Jordan:** Only the handover. A trained supervisor must cover the first shift. I can check the roster, but I cannot ⁴ _____ the training results myself.
- 09 **Aiko:** Understood. Please check the supervisor coverage and send me the assessment result by 3 p.m. branch time on Friday. Can you commit to that update, even if a result is missing?
- 10 **Jordan:** Yes. I can commit to an update, not a passing result. If either result is missing, I will ⁵ _____ it rather than leave the field blank.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the same bank from the previous page. Finish all ten gaps before uncovering the numbered answer strip below.

- 11 **Aiko:** Good distinction. For this decision, I will use three statuses: confirmed, pending, and blocked. "Pending" will mean that we are still waiting for evidence.
- 12 **Jordan:** That works. Could we also separate ⁶ _____ from approval in the minutes? People sometimes say "understood" just to show they have heard the instruction.
- 13 **Aiko:** Yes. I will ask the decision owner to state approval explicitly. In this case that is me, after I review your staffing check.
- 14 **Jordan:** And if I say I have a ⁷ _____, please keep the decision open long enough for me to explain it. I do not mean that I reject the whole plan.
- 15 **Aiko:** Agreed. One last check: if both assessments pass and the supervisor is available, you support Monday. If either condition fails, we discuss a new date. Correct?
- 16 **Jordan:** Correct. That is an accurate ⁸ _____. It captures the conditions without turning them into guarantees.
- 17 **Aiko:** I will amend the minutes now and label Monday provisional. We will make the go/no-go decision after your Friday update, not before it.
- 18 **Jordan:** Please send me the revised paragraph. I can confirm its accuracy today; that confirmation should not be treated as ⁹ _____ to launch.
- 19 **Aiko:** I will make that distinction explicit. Thank you for raising it before the team acted on the old record.
- 20 **Jordan:** Thanks for checking. Next time I will say, "The sequence works; the date is ¹⁰ _____." That leaves less room for a different interpretation.

ANSWERS / COVER THIS STRIP UNTIL YOU FINISH

1. green light | 2. conditional | 3. unconfirmed | 4. certify | 5. flag | 6. acknowledgment | 7. reservation | 8. read-back | 9. authorization | 10. still provisional

A vendor demonstration, not a purchase

F Say it

Aiko and Jordan now discuss a software demonstration. The team likes the interface. Security review is pending, and the purchasing director alone can approve a contract.

Complete the four short exchanges using the bank. Each entry is used once. Read the completed conversation aloud; then check the answer strip.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

approval authority / positive feedback on the demonstration / constitute / subject to

Aiko: "The team likes the interface. May I record that as
1 _____?"

Jordan: "Yes, but the purchase remains 2 _____ security review."

Aiko: "Who has 3 _____ for the contract?"

Jordan: "The purchasing director. Our positive feedback does not 4 _____ that approval."

ANSWERS / COVER THIS STRIP UNTIL YOU FINISH

1. positive feedback on the demonstration | 2. subject to | 3. approval authority | 4. constitute

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-10 with a partner; insert your selected answers without adding facts.
2. Switch roles for turns 11-20. Pause after each clarification question until the partner finishes the printed reply.
3. Read the four-line vendor conversation twice, switching roles. Use the answer key only after both readers have selected their choices.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles aloud. Pause for two seconds at the change of speaker. For the final repeat, cover the bank but keep the case facts and dialogue visible. Restore any missed expression from the answer strip; do not invent replacement facts.

A sharp objection at the budget review

A Read the situation

Probe evidence, make a concession without surrendering the decision, and set a conduct boundary.

Mei proposes a six-week pilot with two account managers. Chris says, "This proposal makes no sense." The plan assumes two hours of follow-up per account each week; the last trial used four. The staffing allocation is fixed for this pilot. Mei can revise the account count, but cannot add staff without separate approval.

PEOPLE / Mei: International branch manager | Chris: US-based commercial lead

TEST THE CLAIM; ADDRESS THE DELIVERY

Some colleagues use debate to test a proposal rather than signal personal dislike. That possibility does not excuse contempt. Ask which assumption is challenged and what evidence would change the conclusion. A claim about the plan is different from a judgment about your competence. If the speaker insults people or repeatedly talks over them, name the behavior and set a limit; you do not need to prove hostile intent before doing so.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use only the briefing. Explanations: page 62.

1. Which assumption is contradicted by the previous trial?

- | | |
|---|--------------------------------------|
| A The pilot lasts six weeks. | B Two managers are allocated. |
| C Follow-up will take two hours. | D Mei chairs the meeting. |

2. Which adjustment is within Mei's stated authority?

- | | |
|---|---|
| A Add a third manager immediately. | B Change the number of pilot accounts. |
| C Guarantee that follow-up will halve. | D Waive all customer-service requirements. |

3. Which response separates the issue from the person?

- | | |
|---|--|
| A Ask for the challenged assumption and supporting evidence. | B Ask whether Chris likes Mei. |
| C Treat the criticism as automatic disloyalty. | D Accept the whole objection without checking it. |

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words

Read the meaning, then say the word combination aloud. The combinations show how the term naturally fits into workplace language.

pushback

Resistance or a challenge to a request or proposal.

IN USE offer constructive pushback

premise

A starting claim on which an argument depends.

IN USE challenge the premise

stress-test

Examine a plan under difficult but plausible conditions.

IN USE stress-test an assumption

counterproposal

A different proposal offered in response.

IN USE put forward a counterproposal

evidence base

The information supporting a conclusion or estimate.

IN USE strengthen the evidence base

concession

A point accepted without necessarily accepting the entire argument.

IN USE make a limited concession

feasibility

Whether something can realistically be done.

IN USE assess feasibility

capacity constraint

A limit on the work available people or systems can handle.

IN USE work within a capacity constraint

non-negotiable

A requirement that cannot be traded away in this discussion.

IN USE state a non-negotiable

personal remark

A comment about a person rather than the issue under review.

IN USE avoid personal remarks

burden of proof

Responsibility for supplying evidence for a claim.

IN USE meet the burden of proof

devil's advocate

Someone testing a position by arguing against it, sometimes without holding that view.

IN USE play devil's advocate

Precision check

A concession accepts a particular point, not necessarily the whole argument. A counterproposal offers a different course of action. Constructive pushback needs neither personal agreement nor personal criticism.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language

Read each complete phrase. The small label names its job in the conversation; the wording remains professional without hiding the point.

ASK FOR THE PREMISE

"Which assumption are you challenging?"

REQUEST EVIDENCE

"What are you basing that estimate on?"

CONCEDE ONE POINT

"I accept the capacity concern; I do not accept that the whole pilot is unworkable."

NAME THE DISTINCTION

"Let us separate the objective from the proposed method."

SET A BOUNDARY

"Challenge the proposal, please, not the competence of the people presenting it."

INVITE AN ALTERNATIVE

"What would a workable version look like within the same staffing limit?"

LIMIT CERTAINTY

"That evidence supports a smaller pilot, not a guaranteed failure."

CLOSE FIRMLY

"We will revise the account count and test the workload before expanding."

Concession + contrast

Use "I accept X; however, Y remains unresolved." Acceptance of one point is not agreement with the whole conclusion.

Calibrated certainty

"The trial suggests" is narrower than "The trial proves." Match the strength of the verb to the evidence available.

Boundary + invitation

Combine a limit with a route back to the work: "No personal remarks. Please show us the workload calculation."

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Choose the response that concedes a fact but preserves a narrower proposal.

- A You are wrong about everything.
- B I accept the four-hour figure; a smaller pilot may still fit.
- C The whole project is canceled.
- D Your tone proves the numbers are false.

2. Complete: "The previous trial ____ a workload risk; it does not prove failure."

- A guarantees
- B eliminates
- C conceals
- D indicates

3. Which sentence sets a conduct boundary without rejecting criticism?

- A Do not question my proposal.
- B Your concern is unwelcome.
- C Please keep the comments on the proposal, not the people.
- D We will stop collecting evidence.

4. Which question asks for a counterproposal within the constraint?

- A How many accounts can two managers support?
- B Why are you so negative?
- C Can we pretend the trial was shorter?
- D Who approved unlimited staffing?

CHECK, CORRECT, REPEAT

Check the explanations on page 62. For each error, read the complete corrected message aloud once. Then reread the relevant phrase on page 14. All four checks must be corrected before you continue.

A sharp objection at the budget review

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. The small raised number identifies the gap, not the turn. Cover the answer strip on the next page.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

counterproposal / concede / retain / premise / stress-test / impact / non-negotiable / evidence gap / validate / scrutiny

- 01 **Chris:** This proposal makes no sense. Two account managers cannot run a pilot on that scale and keep their normal accounts. We will burn through the team before week two.
- 02 **Mei:** I want to understand the objection. Which ¹ _____ are you challenging: the number of accounts, the follow-up time, or the length of the pilot?
- 03 **Chris:** The follow-up time. Your sheet allows two hours per account each week. The last trial took four, and it had fewer handoffs than this one.
- 04 **Mei:** Then we have a specific ² _____, not just a general concern. Can you show us the trial log and explain what is comparable?
- 05 **Chris:** Yes. Here are the entries. Most of the time went into resolving customer questions, not administration. A new template will not remove those conversations.
- 06 **Mei:** I ³ _____ that point. We should not assume the template halves the workload. I am not yet persuaded that we must abandon the pilot.
- 07 **Chris:** If you want my honest view, the team that wrote this has not understood the customers. That is why the estimate is so far off.
- 08 **Mei:** Please keep this on the workload, not the team's competence. I welcome ⁴ _____, but personal judgments will not help us verify the estimate.
- 09 **Chris:** Fair point. That was too personal. My concern is the estimate. I am trying to prevent an overloaded team, not undermine you.
- 10 **Mei:** Thank you for making that clear. We can examine your intent and still address the ⁵ _____ of the wording. Let us return to the numbers.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the same bank from the previous page. Finish all ten gaps before uncovering the numbered answer strip below.

- 11 **Chris:** Within two managers, I would cut the account count in half. We could then measure actual follow-up time before asking for a larger allocation.
- 12 **Mei:** That is a useful ⁶ _____. Keeping the staffing fixed matters, because additional headcount would need a different approval.
- 13 **Chris:** Would a smaller sample tell us enough? I do not want to solve the staffing problem by creating a pilot that cannot answer the business question.
- 14 **Mei:** We need to test that. A smaller sample may give directional evidence, but it will not ⁷ _____ a full rollout. We will state that limitation in the review.
- 15 **Chris:** Then I can support a smaller pilot if we agree on what it can and cannot establish. I would also want a workload check after the first week.
- 16 **Mei:** Agreed. The staffing limit is ⁸ _____ for this decision, but the account count and review points are open to adjustment.
- 17 **Chris:** I will work with operations on the revised count. I also owe the team a correction for the remark about their understanding of customers.
- 18 **Mei:** Please make that correction in the same group. We can ⁹ _____ the disagreement about the design without leaving the personal remark unaddressed.
- 19 **Chris:** Understood. I accept that the original estimate needs work, but not that anyone acted carelessly. I will say that before we circulate the revision.
- 20 **Mei:** Good. Our decision is to ¹⁰ _____ the workload assumption with a smaller pilot, not to treat either of today's estimates as a guarantee.

ANSWERS / COVER THIS STRIP UNTIL YOU FINISH

1. premise | 2. evidence gap | 3. concede | 4. scrutiny | 5. impact | 6. counterproposal | 7. validate | 8. non-negotiable | 9. retain | 10. stress-test

Challenge a sales forecast

F Say it

A forecast assumes ten renewals. Only seven customers have confirmed. You can revise the forecast, but you cannot promise the other three renewals.

Complete the four short exchanges using the bank. Each entry is used once. Read the completed conversation aloud; then check the answer strip.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

possible / confirmations / assumption / can substantiate

Chris: "The forecast is optimistic. Which ¹ _____ support ten renewals?"

Mei: "I ² _____ seven confirmed renewals, not ten."

Chris: "Then label the other three as ³ _____, not committed."

Mei: "Agreed. We will challenge the ⁴ _____, not the forecaster's character."

ANSWERS / COVER THIS STRIP UNTIL YOU FINISH

1. confirmations | 2. can substantiate | 3. possible | 4. assumption

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-10 once with a neutral tone and once with firm emphasis on "workload" and "competence." Keep the words unchanged.
2. Switch roles for turns 11-20. Pause at each concession or boundary; the listener repeats that exact phrase before continuing.
3. Complete the forecast conversation, then read it without substituting "confirmed" for "possible."

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles aloud. Pause for two seconds at the change of speaker. For the final repeat, cover the bank but keep the case facts and dialogue visible. Restore any missed expression from the answer strip; do not invent replacement facts.

Delegating without disappearing

A Read the situation

03

Define decision rights, invite recommendations, and delegate within explicit limits.

Sofia has been approving every small change to an onboarding process. Alex wants the team to act faster but does not know where its authority ends. For this fictional project, Sofia can delegate changes to internal task order. Customer promises and additional spending still require her approval. A process trial will run for two weeks.

PEOPLE / Sofia: International customer-service manager | Alex: US-based team lead

CONSULTATION IS NOT A VOTE

A manager can invite disagreement and still own the final decision. Conversely, an invitation to "take ownership" does not tell a team which decisions it can make. The missing information is authority, not confidence. Specify what is delegated, what needs consultation, and what remains reserved. Do not equate an employee's request for clarity with reluctance to lead, or a confident suggestion with a claim to unlimited authority.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use only the briefing. Explanations: page 63.

1. Which decision can Sofia delegate in this case?

- A** Any new customer promise
- C** Internal task order

- B** Additional spending
- D** All employment decisions

2. What remains reserved to Sofia?

- A** Naming a working file
- C** Every routine conversation

- B** Customer promises and extra spending
- D** The team's personal preferences

3. How long will the process trial run?

- A** Two days
- C** An unspecified period

- B** Two months
- D** Two weeks

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words

Read the meaning, then say the word combination aloud. The combinations show how the term naturally fits into workplace language.

decision rights

Who may recommend, approve, or decide a particular matter.

IN USE clarify decision rights

delegation

Giving another person defined responsibility or authority.

IN USE delegate a decision

discretion

Freedom to choose within stated limits.

IN USE exercise discretion

guardrail

A limit intended to keep a decision within an acceptable range.

IN USE set clear guardrails

escalation threshold

The point at which an issue must go to another authority.

IN USE agree an escalation threshold

decision owner

The person accountable for making a particular decision.

IN USE name the decision owner

consultation

Seeking input before an action or decision.

IN USE hold a consultation

consensus

Broad agreement, which must not be inferred from silence alone.

IN USE build consensus

accountability

Responsibility for explaining actions and following through.

IN USE retain accountability

remit

The area of work or authority assigned to a role.

IN USE stay within your remit

exception

A case that falls outside the normal rule or arrangement.

IN USE approve an exception

RACI

A role map: Responsible, Accountable, Consulted, Informed. Organizations may apply it differently.

IN USE use a RACI matrix

Precision check

Consultation asks for input; consensus requires shared agreement. Delegation grants specified authority, not unlimited discretion. State the remit and escalation threshold before asking someone to take ownership.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language

Read each complete phrase. The small label names its job in the conversation; the wording remains professional without hiding the point.

INVITE A RECOMMENDATION

"Bring me your preferred option and the reason for it."

RESERVE A DECISION

"Customer commitments remain my decision."

DEFINE AN ESCALATION

"If the change affects a customer promise, bring it back to me."

PREVENT SILENT CONSENT

"I will ask each owner to confirm the responsibilities assigned to them."

DELEGATE CLEARLY

"You may change the internal sequence without seeking approval each time."

SET A LIMIT

"That discretion does not include additional spending."

DISTINGUISH ROLES

"I need your input; I am not asking you to make the final decision."

SCHEDULE REVIEW

"We will review the trial after two weeks using the agreed criteria."

Permission and obligation

"You may" grants permission. "You must" states a requirement. "You can" may describe either ability or permission; make the context explicit.

Within and beyond

"Within your remit" identifies permitted scope. "Beyond your remit" signals a need for a different owner or approval.

Consult versus approve

"Consult finance" requires input; it does not automatically give finance final approval authority. State the actual arrangement.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which instruction delegates authority with a clear boundary?

- A Use your judgment about everything.
- B Wait for me before changing any file.
- C Act as if every request is approved.
- D Reorder internal tasks; seek approval before changing customer promises.

2. Complete: "You ___ notify me if a change affects a customer promise." The requirement is compulsory.

- A might
- B must
- C could
- D may

3. Which statement describes consultation, not approval?

- A Finance supplies cost information before Sofia decides.
- B Finance authorizes the spending.
- C Finance issues final sign-off.
- D Finance has vetoed the request.

4. The team disagrees after everyone has contributed. What is still possible?

- A Silence can be recorded as unanimous approval.
- B No decision owner can exist.
- C Sofia can decide after considering the input.
- D The newest employee must approve.

CHECK, CORRECT, REPEAT

Check the explanations on page 63. For each error, read the complete corrected message aloud once. Then reread the relevant phrase on page 21. All four checks must be corrected before you continue.

Delegating without disappearing

E Conversations / turns 1-10

03

Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. The small raised number identifies the gap, not the turn. Cover the answer strip on the next page.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

discretion / remit / escalation threshold / decision rights / review / consulted / responsibilities / delegated / accountability / exception

- 01 **Alex:** The team wants more freedom on onboarding, but "take ownership" has not been clear enough. Yesterday we waited for your reply before moving a routine internal check.
- 02 **Sofia:** That is a fair criticism. I have asked for initiative without defining the ¹ _____. Let us separate what you can decide from what needs my approval.
- 03 **Alex:** Our recommendation is to move the internal document check earlier. It would not change what we promise customers or require additional spending.
- 04 **Sofia:** You have my permission to decide the internal task order. That is now ² _____ to you for the two-week trial; you do not need to ask about each change.
- 05 **Alex:** Does that include changing a customer's promised completion date if an internal delay makes the original date difficult?
- 06 **Sofia:** No. Customer promises are outside that ³ _____. Bring those changes to me with the reason and the options before making a new commitment.
- 07 **Alex:** Understood. And if the team wants a paid document-checking tool, we should stop at the spending boundary rather than order it and tell you afterward.
- 08 **Sofia:** Exactly. Additional spending is an ⁴ _____ that needs approval. The team can research the tool and recommend it, but not purchase it under this delegation.
- 09 **Alex:** I would like input from customer support before choosing the sequence. Do they need to agree, or is their role to identify problems we might miss?
- 10 **Sofia:** For the internal sequence, they are ⁵ _____. You make the decision after using their input. Do not describe their silence as agreement.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

03

Continue with the same bank from the previous page. Finish all ten gaps before uncovering the numbered answer strip below.

- 11 **Alex:** Then I will send them two options and ask for risks by Thursday noon. If they need more time, they can say so rather than approve by default.
- 12 **Sofia:** Good. If a disagreement concerns only internal order, resolve it within your ⁶ _____. If it affects a customer promise, bring it to me.
- 13 **Alex:** Who is accountable if the trial causes extra rework? I do not want the team to hear that I own the decision but have no access to support.
- 14 **Sofia:** I retain management ⁷ _____ for the trial. You are responsible for coordinating it, collecting the results, and raising issues promptly. I will help remove obstacles.
- 15 **Alex:** That sounds workable. Could we put those roles on one page? Some people are familiar with RACI, while others will need the terms explained.
- 16 **Sofia:** Yes. Use plain role descriptions first. A matrix is useful only if the team understands the ⁸ _____, not just the letters.
- 17 **Alex:** I will record the boundary as: internal sequence, Alex decides; customer promises or spending, Sofia approves. Support provides input before the sequence is chosen.
- 18 **Sofia:** That captures it. Add an ⁹ _____: contact me before a proposed change would alter either a customer promise or the spending limit.
- 19 **Alex:** I will circulate that today and ask each named person to confirm their role. Then we can start the trial on Monday.
- 20 **Sofia:** And we will hold the ¹⁰ _____ at the end of week two. Bring the rework count and the time taken; we will decide whether to keep, adjust, or stop the sequence.

ANSWERS / COVER THIS STRIP UNTIL YOU FINISH

1. decision rights | 2. delegated | 3. remit | 4. exception | 5. consulted | 6. discretion | 7. accountability | 8. responsibilities | 9. escalation threshold | 10. review

A conference booking

F Say it

03

Sofia permits Alex to choose a room within an approved \$2,000 budget. Changes to the event date require Sofia's approval. No extra spending is authorized.

Complete the four short exchanges using the bank. Each entry is used once. Read the completed conversation aloud; then check the answer strip.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

my decision / may / approval boundary / seek your approval

Sofia: "You ¹ _____ choose the room within the approved budget."

Alex: "If every suitable room costs more, I will ² _____ before booking."

Sofia: "Changing the event date remains ³ _____."

Alex: "I will record the budget and the ⁴ _____ so the team knows when to contact you."

ANSWERS / COVER THIS STRIP UNTIL YOU FINISH

1. may | 2. seek your approval | 3. my decision | 4. approval boundary

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read the dialogue with one reader as Sofia and one as Alex. After turns 4, 6, and 10, repeat the stated permission or boundary exactly.
2. Switch roles and read turns 15-20 as a decision-record check. Do not add authority that the record does not grant.
3. Read the conference exchange using the selected options. Finish by repeating the budget and the reserved date decision.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles aloud. Pause for two seconds at the change of speaker. For the final repeat, cover the bank but keep the case facts and dialogue visible. Restore any missed expression from the answer strip; do not invent replacement facts.

Friday estimates or Monday verified figures

04

A Read the situation

Offer bounded alternatives, use conditional commitments, and distinguish a forecast from a promise.

Headquarters needs branch figures for a Friday planning meeting. Omar can send an estimate by 3 p.m. New York time on Friday or verified figures by noon New York time on Monday. The supplier reconciliation will not finish before Monday morning. Priya can choose the reporting option but cannot make reconciliation finish early. Estimates must be labeled as provisional.

PEOPLE / Omar: International branch operations manager | Priya: Headquarters project sponsor

A CLEAR LIMIT CAN PROTECT TRUST

A quick "yes" may reduce tension in the call while creating a commitment the branch cannot meet. A vague "we will try" can also be heard as a promise. Name the deliverable, deadline, and condition separately. Offer a choice that serves the other person's purpose. Do not present willingness as capacity, or describe a required accuracy check as resistance to headquarters.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use only the briefing. Explanations: page 64.

1. What can Omar supply on Friday?

A Verified figures

B A labeled estimate

C A completed reconciliation

D A guaranteed final result

2. What cannot Priya change simply by choosing an option?

A The report's intended use

B The meeting audience

C The reconciliation completion constraint

D Whether to accept an estimate

3. Which time description is fully specified?

A Friday afternoon somewhere

B End of day

C Before lunch

D Friday at 3 p.m. New York time

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words

Read the meaning, then say the word combination aloud. The combinations show how the term naturally fits into workplace language.

deliverable

A specific output someone agrees to provide.

IN USE define the deliverable

turnaround time

Time from a request or input to a completed response.

IN USE agree a turnaround time

trade-off

A choice in which one benefit comes at the cost of another.

IN USE make a trade-off

reconciliation

Checking records against one another and resolving differences.

IN USE complete the reconciliation

verified

Checked against the required evidence or process.

IN USE verified figures

estimate

An approximate figure based on available information.

IN USE provide an estimate

caveat

A stated limitation or qualification.

IN USE include a caveat

scope creep

Uncontrolled growth of the work beyond the agreed scope.

IN USE prevent scope creep

contingency

A provision or alternative for a possible problem.

IN USE plan a contingency

hard deadline

A deadline treated as fixed for the stated purpose.

IN USE meet a hard deadline

best effort

An undertaking to try, not necessarily to deliver a result.

IN USE make a best-effort attempt

overcommit

Promise more than the available capacity can support.

IN USE avoid overcommitting

Precision check

A deliverable is the output promised; a deadline is when it is due. A caveat states a limitation; a contingency states the fallback. An estimate can be useful without being verified, provided its status stays visible.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language

Read each complete phrase. The small label names its job in the conversation; the wording remains professional without hiding the point.

IDENTIFY THE PURPOSE

"What decision does the Friday meeting need to make?"

OFFER ALTERNATIVES

"We can provide an estimate on Friday or verified figures on Monday."

MAKE A CONDITIONAL OFFER

"We can meet Friday if the deliverable is an explicitly provisional estimate."

STATE A FIRM LIMIT

"I cannot commit to verified figures before the reconciliation is complete."

PROTECT THE CAVEAT

"Please keep the provisional label when the figures are forwarded."

CHECK THE DEADLINE

"Does 'Friday' mean 3 p.m. New York time or your local end of day?"

SEPARATE EFFORT FROM OUTCOME

"I can commit to the update; I cannot guarantee a result we do not control."

CONFIRM THE CHOICE

"Then our agreement is Friday estimates, followed by Monday verification."

If + present tense

Use "If the scope stays the same, we can send the estimate on Friday." Do not use "if the scope will stay" for this ordinary future condition.

Provided that

"Provided that" makes a requirement explicit. It does not mean the requirement has already been met.

Cannot versus will not

"Cannot verify before Monday" describes a constraint. "Will not verify" can imply a refusal; select the meaning you intend.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Choose the commitment supported by the facts.

- A We guarantee final figures Friday.
- B We can finish reconciliation tonight.
- C We can send a labeled estimate Friday at 3 p.m. New York time.
- D No report of any kind is possible.

2. Complete the ordinary future condition: "If you ___ the estimate option, we can meet Friday."

- A choose
- B will choose
- C would have chosen
- D choosing

3. Which caveat preserves the status of the Friday figures?

- A Final and verified
- B Provisional; reconciliation pending
- C Approved for every purpose
- D Guaranteed not to change

4. Which reply clarifies purpose before negotiating the deliverable?

- A Why do you always rush us?
- B We will say yes and work it out later.
- C Accuracy does not matter.
- D Is Friday's decision about planning capacity or final reporting?

CHECK, CORRECT, REPEAT

Check the explanations on page 64. For each error, read the complete corrected message aloud once. Then reread the relevant phrase on page 28. All four checks must be corrected before you continue.

Friday estimates or Monday verified figures

E Conversations / turns 1-10

04

Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. The small raised number identifies the gap, not the turn. Cover the answer strip on the next page.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

scope creep / caveat / contingency / deliverable / guarantee / provided that / trade-off / reconciliation / commit / provisional

- 01 **Priya:** The planning group needs your branch figures on Friday. Can you send the final report before the meeting? We cannot move the meeting to Monday.
- 02 **Omar:** I can help with Friday, but I need to be clear about the ¹ _____. We can send an estimate then; Monday is our target for verified figures.
- 03 **Priya:** We used the word "final" because the group needs one number in the deck. What prevents you from checking the estimate before Friday?
- 04 **Omar:** The supplier ² _____ will not finish before Monday morning. That is a missing check, not a choice to delay the report.
- 05 **Priya:** The group will use the number to compare staffing options. It is not making a final financial filing. Would an estimate be adequate for that discussion?
- 06 **Omar:** Yes, with a clear ³ _____. I can provide the estimate, its basis, and the items not yet reconciled. I cannot describe it as verified.
- 07 **Priya:** Could you remove that warning from the main slide and put it in the notes? The slide is already crowded.
- 08 **Omar:** I need the ⁴ _____ label to stay beside the figure. Otherwise readers may treat the estimate as final when the slide is forwarded without its notes.
- 09 **Priya:** Understood. Keep a short label on the slide and the detail in the notes. What is the earliest time you can send it?
- 10 **Omar:** Friday at 3 p.m. New York time, ⁵ _____ the scope remains this branch and the current reporting period. Adding other branches would change the schedule.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the same bank from the previous page. Finish all ten gaps before uncovering the numbered answer strip below.

- 11 **Priya:** That time works. I was about to add two other branches, but we can leave them out of this version. I will state that in the request.
- 12 **Omar:** Thank you. That avoids ⁶ _____ after we have agreed the deadline. Please send the confirmed scope so I can brief the team accurately.
- 13 **Priya:** For Monday, can I tell the group that the verified number will definitely match Friday's estimate? A change could prompt more questions.
- 14 **Omar:** No. Verification may change it. I can ⁷ _____ to explaining any difference; I cannot guarantee that the number itself will remain unchanged.
- 15 **Priya:** Then we need to explain that before the group makes a decision. I will frame Friday's figure as a planning input, not a certified result.
- 16 **Omar:** That is the right ⁸ _____: speed for the planning meeting, followed by a checked result. We should not claim to have both on Friday.
- 17 **Priya:** What will you do if the supplier check is unexpectedly still incomplete on Monday morning? I would rather hear about a delay early.
- 18 **Omar:** Our ⁹ _____ will be an explicit status update before noon, identifying what remains unresolved and when we can reassess. I will not relabel unchecked data as verified.
- 19 **Priya:** Agreed. I will record the Friday estimate and Monday verified-report target, with that fallback if the supplier check is delayed.
- 20 **Omar:** Please also record that the Friday estimate is not a ¹⁰ _____ of Monday's outcome. With that wording, I can confirm the commitment and brief the team.

ANSWERS / COVER THIS STRIP UNTIL YOU FINISH

1. deliverable | 2. reconciliation | 3. caveat | 4. provisional | 5. provided that | 6. scope creep | 7. commit | 8. trade-off | 9. contingency | 10. guarantee

A presentation with an unfinished review

F Say it

A client presentation is due Tuesday. A ten-slide draft can be ready then, but compliance review finishes Wednesday. Only the reviewed version can be sent externally.

Complete the four short exchanges using the bank. Each entry is used once. Read the completed conversation aloud; then check the answer strip.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

review pending / internal / finishes / until

Priya: "Can you deliver ten slides Tuesday?" Omar: "Yes, as an ¹ _____ draft."

Priya: "Can the client receive it then?" Omar: "Not ² _____ review is complete."

Priya: "Then I will call Tuesday's file ³ _____."

Omar: "If the review ⁴ _____ Wednesday, we can prepare the approved version for release."

ANSWERS / COVER THIS STRIP UNTIL YOU FINISH

1. internal | 2. until | 3. review pending | 4. finishes

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read the full dialogue, pausing after each offer so the listener can repeat its deadline and condition.
2. Switch roles and reread turns 7-14. Keep the distinction between a provisional figure and a guaranteed result.
3. Read the presentation exchange with the selected words. Finish by repeating which file may be sent externally.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles aloud. Pause for two seconds at the change of speaker. For the final repeat, cover the bank but keep the case facts and dialogue visible. Restore any missed expression from the answer strip; do not invent replacement facts.

The remote question nobody heard

A Read the situation

Manage turn-taking, interrupt constructively, paraphrase accurately, and close a hybrid meeting.

Three participants have been speaking over one another. Arun posted a concern in the meeting chat, but nobody responded. The team has fifteen minutes left. The new queue can go live only after routing is checked; Arun has not completed that check. Leila owns the go-live decision, and Ben has been preparing the customer-service schedule.

PEOPLE / Leila: International manager and meeting chair | Ben: US-based service lead | Arun: Remote systems lead

PROTECT ACCESS, NOT JUST AIRTIME

Someone may be quiet because of audio delay, language-processing time, a missed invitation, or uncertainty about the decision. Do not diagnose the reason from silence. Give the remote participant a named turn, stop overlapping speech, and summarize the contribution before moving on. First-name address or an informal manner does not establish that hierarchy has disappeared. The chair still needs to state who decides and whose input is missing.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use only the briefing. Explanations: page 65.

1. Whose input has been missed?

- | | |
|---------------------------------------|--|
| A Leila's decision | B Arun's routing concern |
| C A customer's signed approval | D An unnamed supplier's invoice |

2. What blocks a final go-live decision?

- | | |
|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| A A completed routing check | B A full transcript |
| C An unfinished routing check | D A new office location |

3. Who owns the go-live decision?

- | | |
|---------------------|------------------------------|
| A Leila | B Ben |
| C Arun alone | D Whoever speaks last |

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words

Read the meaning, then say the word combination aloud. The combinations show how the term naturally fits into workplace language.

turn-taking

The way speakers enter, hold, and give up a speaking turn.

IN USE manage turn-taking

the floor

The opportunity to speak to the group.

IN USE give someone the floor

crosstalk

Overlapping speech that makes contributions hard to follow.

IN USE reduce crosstalk

timebox

A fixed amount of time allocated to a discussion or task.

IN USE timebox the discussion

round-robin

A sequence in which each participant is invited to contribute.

IN USE use a round-robin

paraphrase

Restate someone's meaning in different words.

IN USE paraphrase a concern

parking lot

An informal list of issues deferred for later attention.

IN USE put an item in the parking lot

dissent

A stated view that differs from the proposal or majority view.

IN USE record dissent

quorum

The minimum attendance required under a group's rules for valid business.

IN USE confirm a quorum

action item

A specific task recorded for follow-up.

IN USE assign an action item

decision log

A record of decisions, owners, and relevant reasons or conditions.

IN USE update the decision log

asynchronous input

A contribution made outside a simultaneous meeting.

IN USE collect asynchronous input

Precision check

Giving someone the floor transfers the speaking turn, not decision authority. An action item assigns work; a decision log records what has been decided or remains pending. Neither silence nor attendance establishes approval.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language

Read each complete phrase. The small label names its job in the conversation; the wording remains professional without hiding the point.

STOP OVERLAP

"One voice at a time, please; the remote line cannot distinguish us."

PROTECT A TURN

"Arun has not finished. I will come to you next, Ben."

ENTER THE DISCUSSION

"May I come in on the routing point before we move on?"

INVITE A SPECIFIC VIEW

"Arun, what remains unverified in the routing check?"

CHECK A PARAPHRASE

"Have I represented your concern accurately?"

LIMIT A DIGRESSION

"Let us park the training format and finish the go-live conditions."

RECORD DISSENT

"I will record the concern without describing it as agreement."

CLOSE WITH OWNERSHIP

"The next action belongs to Arun; the go-live decision remains with me."

A useful interruption

State the reason briefly: "Before we move on, Arun's question is still open." This protects an unresolved issue rather than merely taking airtime.

Paraphrase versus infer

"You said the check is incomplete" reports a contribution. "You do not support the project" adds a position the speaker may not hold.

An invitation that can be answered

"Any thoughts?" is broad. "What remains unverified?" gives the invited speaker a precise task.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Choose the intervention that protects the interrupted speaker.

- A Arun, send an email instead; we are moving on.
- B Ben, please finish Arun's explanation.
- C Arun has not finished; Ben will speak next.
- D Everyone speak more loudly.

2. Which paraphrase does not add an unsupported conclusion?

- A Arun wants to cancel the project.
- B Arun said the routing check is incomplete.
- C Arun has approved the routing.
- D Arun refuses to work with Ben.

3. Which action belongs in a decision log?

- A A guess about why someone was quiet
- B A comment about someone's accent
- C A record that all silence meant agreement
- D Go-live pending; Arun checks routing; Leila decides afterward.

4. Which issue must not be parked before this go-live decision?

- A The unfinished routing check
- B The next social event
- C The color of an internal folder
- D A future office layout

CHECK, CORRECT, REPEAT

Check the explanations on page 65. For each error, read the complete corrected message aloud once. Then reread the relevant phrase on page 35. All four checks must be corrected before you continue.

The remote question nobody heard

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. The small raised number identifies the gap, not the turn. Cover the answer strip on the next page.

05

WORD + PHRASE BANK

timebox / paraphrase / decision log / crosstalk / asynchronous input / decision / dissent / the floor / action items / parking lot

- 01 **Ben:** If we start Monday, the schedule is ready. I think we have covered the main points, so can we confirm the switch and send the roster?
- 02 **Leila:** Before we confirm anything, we need to stop the ¹ _____. Three people were speaking, and I could not hear the remote contribution.
- 03 **Arun:** Thank you. I put a question in the chat about routing, but the discussion moved to staffing. I am not saying the schedule is wrong; the technical check is still open.
- 04 **Ben:** I saw a message appear, but I did not read it fully. Arun, you have ² _____. What is the unresolved part?
- 05 **Arun:** We have checked new tickets, but not tickets transferred from the old queue. If those transfers are misrouted, the schedule will not prevent delays.
- 06 **Leila:** Let me ³ _____ that: new tickets have passed the check; transferred tickets have not. So we cannot treat the complete routing check as finished. Is that accurate?
- 07 **Arun:** Yes. I need a test set of transferred tickets and someone from service to confirm that they reach the intended team.
- 08 **Ben:** I can supply that test set. But could we first discuss the training slides? There are several changes I would like to make to the layout.
- 09 **Leila:** Let us put the slide layout in the ⁴ _____. We have fifteen minutes for the go-live conditions, and the routing check is a prerequisite.
- 10 **Arun:** That helps. I need ten representative transferred tickets, not another overview of the training. Ben, can your team provide those by 11 a.m. tomorrow?

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the same bank from the previous page. Finish all ten gaps before uncovering the numbered answer strip below.

- 11 **Ben:** Yes. I can assign that today. I also want to clarify that preparing the roster did not mean I had authority to approve the switch.
- 12 **Leila:** Correct. The go-live ⁵ _____ is mine. Preparing the schedule is an action, not an approval. I will make that distinction in the record.
- 13 **Arun:** May I add one more condition? I need a service colleague in the test, otherwise we will know the technical destination but not whether the operational routing is useful.
- 14 **Leila:** Yes. I will give you a short ⁶ _____ to finish the conditions, then we will confirm the owner of each task. Ben, please hold your reply until Arun finishes.
- 15 **Arun:** That is the full list: representative transfers and a service colleague. If those are available tomorrow, I can report the test result that afternoon.
- 16 **Ben:** I will name the service colleague and supply the ten tickets. Please record both as my ⁷ _____, with the 11 a.m. deadline.
- 17 **Leila:** Recorded. Arun reports the test result tomorrow afternoon; I decide afterward. Until then, the proposed switch remains pending, not approved.
- 18 **Arun:** Please also record my ⁸ _____ from treating Monday as final today. I support testing the switch; I do not support releasing it before the check.
- 19 **Ben:** That distinction is clear. I will hold the announcement. If anyone misses the remaining discussion, I will collect their input in the shared note rather than infer agreement.
- 20 **Leila:** Good. The ⁹ _____ will show the pending decision and named owners. We will accept ¹⁰ _____ until tomorrow's check so absent colleagues can identify relevant risks.

ANSWERS / COVER THIS STRIP UNTIL YOU FINISH

1. crosstalk | 2. the floor | 3. paraphrase | 4. parking lot | 5. decision | 6. timebox | 7. action items | 8. dissent | 9. decision log | 10. asynchronous input

A quiet participant on a video call

F Say it

Nora has not spoken. The chair sees her raised-hand signal. The team must check a missing contract attachment before approving a handover.

Complete the four short exchanges using the bank. Each entry is used once. Read the completed conversation aloud; then check the answer strip.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

paraphrase / the floor / decision log / pending

Chair: "Nora has raised her hand. Let us give her ¹ _____."

Nora: "The attachment is missing; approval is still ² _____."

Chair: "I will ³ _____ your point: we need the attachment before approval."

Nora: "Correct. Please record that in the ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / COVER THIS STRIP UNTIL YOU FINISH

1. the floor | 2. pending | 3. paraphrase | 4. decision log

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Use three readers for the extended dialogue. With two readers, one takes Ben and Arun; alone, read all roles aloud.
2. Read turns 5-7 twice. On the second reading, pause before "Is that accurate?" and wait for the printed confirmation.
3. Read the video-call exchange, then repeat the four completed lines without changing "pending" to "approved."

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles aloud. Pause for two seconds at the change of speaker. For the final repeat, cover the bank but keep the case facts and dialogue visible. Restore any missed expression from the answer strip; do not invent replacement facts.

Two late reports and one missing handoff

A Read the situation

Describe behavior, explain operational impact, ask about causes, and agree a measurable next step.

06

The weekly report is due at noon on Thursday. In each of the last two weeks it arrived on Friday morning. Planning had to defer a staffing update. Elena does not know why the reports were late. Diego depends on a source file from another team. This is a coaching discussion, not a fictional disciplinary procedure.

PEOPLE / Elena: International department manager | Diego: US-based analyst

SPECIFIC IS CLEARER THAN SEVERE

Feedback can be direct without making a claim about character. Name the two reports and their effect; then ask what happened. "You lack commitment" guesses at motivation. "The last two reports arrived after our agreed deadline" names an observable pattern. The Center for Creative Leadership's Situation-Behavior-Impact approach informs this distinction [2]. Once a cause is explained, a manager can offer support without quietly removing the deadline.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use only the briefing. Explanations: page 66.

1. Which statement describes an observation?

A Diego does not care.

B Diego dislikes the team.

C The last two reports arrived Friday morning.

D Diego always ignores deadlines.

2. What operational effect is known?

A Planning deferred its staffing update.

B A customer ended a contract.

C The branch lost a stated amount of money.

D Diego was formally disciplined.

3. What should Elena avoid assuming before asking?

A The deadline was Thursday noon.

B The cause of the delay.

C There were two late reports.

D Planning used the report.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words

Read the meaning, then say the word combination aloud. The combinations show how the term naturally fits into workplace language.

observable behavior

An action that can be described without guessing at motive.

IN USE describe observable behavior

impact

The effect of an action on people or work.

IN USE explain the impact

attribution

An explanation assigned to someone's behavior or an event.

IN USE check an attribution

pattern

A repeated feature across more than one event.

IN USE identify a pattern

bottleneck

A point that limits the flow or speed of work.

IN USE remove a bottleneck

upstream input

Information or work required from an earlier stage or another team.

IN USE obtain upstream input

lead time

The interval needed before an output or action can be ready.

IN USE allow sufficient lead time

corrective action

An agreed step to address a problem or prevent its recurrence.

IN USE agree corrective action

check-in

A brief conversation to review status or provide support.

IN USE schedule a check-in

follow-through

Carrying out what was agreed, not just agreeing to it.

IN USE demonstrate follow-through

performance expectation

A clear description of the work standard required.

IN USE clarify a performance expectation

SBI

Situation-Behavior-Impact: CCL's sequence for specific feedback.

IN USE use an SBI structure [2]

Precision check

An impact is an effect you can describe; an attribution is an explanation you assign. Check the explanation before treating it as a fact. A check-in reviews progress; follow-through means carrying out the agreed action.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language

Read each complete phrase. The small label names its job in the conversation; the wording remains professional without hiding the point.

NAME THE OCCASION

"For each of the last two weekly reports, we agreed on Thursday noon."

DESCRIBE THE BEHAVIOR

"Both reports arrived on Friday morning."

EXPLAIN IMPACT

"Planning had to defer its staffing update while it waited for the figures."

ASK WITHOUT ASSIGNING MOTIVE

"What prevented the Thursday delivery?"

SEPARATE CAUSE FROM STANDARD

"That explains the delay; we still need an early warning when the input is missing."

OFFER CONCRETE SUPPORT

"I will speak with the source-team manager about the handoff."

SET A TRIGGER

"If the file is missing by Wednesday noon, notify me that day."

DEFINE FOLLOW-UP

"We will review the next two reports at a short Friday check-in."

Past evidence, present expectation

Use past tense for the two arrivals. Use present or future wording for the agreed standard and next steps.

Avoid always and never

Two observed events support "the last two reports," not "you always miss deadlines." Keep the claim as narrow as the evidence.

Question before conclusion

"What prevented delivery?" seeks a cause. "Why were you careless?" builds an unverified judgment into the question.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which opening is specific and evidence-based?

- A Your attitude is a problem.
- B You never do what you promise.
- C Everyone thinks you are unreliable.
- D The last two reports arrived Friday, after Thursday's noon deadline.

2. Which question does not assume fault or motive?

- A Why did you deliberately delay it?
- B What prevented the Thursday delivery?
- C Why do you dislike planning?
- D How long have you ignored the team?

3. Choose the early-warning trigger.

- A Let me know if anything ever seems wrong.
- B Try harder next time.
- C If the source file is missing Wednesday noon, notify me that day.
- D Wait until the next report is late.

4. Which statement preserves the expectation while offering support?

- A I will address the handoff; you still need to flag missing input early.
- B No deadline applies once another team is involved.
- C Keep the missing file secret until Friday.
- D Promise the report even when the data do not exist.

CHECK, CORRECT, REPEAT

Check the explanations on page 66. For each error, read the complete corrected message aloud once. Then reread the relevant phrase on page 42. All four checks must be corrected before you continue.

Two late reports and one missing handoff

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. The small raised number identifies the gap, not the turn. Cover the answer strip on the next page.

06

WORD + PHRASE BANK

corrective / lead time / observable behavior / impact / follow-through / bottleneck / check-in / upstream input / performance expectation / flagged

- 01 **Elena:** I want to discuss the last two weekly reports. We agreed on Thursday noon, and both arrived Friday morning. Planning had to defer its staffing update while it waited.
- 02 **Diego:** I understand the ¹ _____. I knew the reports were late, but I did not realize the staffing update had been held back.
- 03 **Elena:** What prevented Thursday delivery? I have the arrival times, but I do not yet know what happened earlier in the process.
- 04 **Diego:** The source file from regional operations arrived late both weeks. That ² _____ is needed before I can finish the totals; I cannot verify them from the dashboard alone.
- 05 **Elena:** When did you know the file was at risk? I am asking about the timing so we can find a useful point for an earlier update.
- 06 **Diego:** By Wednesday afternoon. I expected it overnight and did not want to send another message without a solution. That left too little ³ _____ for you to help.
- 07 **Elena:** Thank you for explaining. The late file explains the production delay. It does not remove the need to warn us when the deadline is at risk.
- 08 **Diego:** Agreed. I should have ⁴ _____ the missing input on Wednesday instead of waiting for a complete answer. An update could have stated what was missing.
- 09 **Elena:** For the next report, notify me if the source file is missing by Wednesday noon. Name the file, the owner, and the effect on Thursday delivery.
- 10 **Diego:** I can do that. Could you also help address the ⁵ _____ with regional operations? They may not know their delivery time determines ours.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the same bank from the previous page. Finish all ten gaps before uncovering the numbered answer strip below.

- 11 **Elena:** Yes. I will speak with their manager and agree a handoff time. I will not promise a new source-file deadline on their behalf before that conversation.
- 12 **Diego:** Then our ⁶ _____ action has two parts: an agreed source handoff and an early-warning message from me if the input is missing.
- 13 **Elena:** Correct. The report remains due Thursday noon unless we explicitly agree otherwise. If the figures cannot be verified, label their status instead of filling the gap with an unsupported number.
- 14 **Diego:** That makes the ⁷ _____ clear. A timely warning is not the same as a completed report, but it lets us decide how to handle the risk.
- 15 **Elena:** Exactly. We will review the next two reports together. I want to see whether the handoff and warning process work, not judge your intentions from one outcome.
- 16 **Diego:** Could we schedule a short Friday ⁸ _____ for those two weeks? That would give us a fixed point to review what happened.
- 17 **Elena:** Yes, ten minutes at 10 a.m. We will use the delivery time and the warning record. If the source file is still late, we will take that evidence to its owner.
- 18 **Diego:** I appreciate the specific approach. When I heard "late reports," I expected a comment about my attitude, not a discussion of ⁹ _____ and the workflow.
- 19 **Elena:** The facts matter more than a label. You have explained the dependency, and we have agreed what each of us will do. I will send that summary today.
- 20 **Diego:** I will confirm the summary and use the Wednesday trigger. The next step is ¹⁰ _____, not just agreeing that the conversation went well.

06

ANSWERS / COVER THIS STRIP UNTIL YOU FINISH

1. impact | 2. upstream input | 3. lead time | 4. flagged | 5. bottleneck | 6. corrective | 7. performance expectation | 8. check-in | 9. observable behavior | 10. follow-through

A missed status update

F Say it

An engineer missed two agreed Tuesday updates. The manager knows the dates but does not know the reason. The next update is still due Tuesday at 2 p.m.

Complete the four short exchanges using the bank. Each entry is used once. Read the completed conversation aloud; then check the answer strip.

06

WORD + PHRASE BANK

remains due / prevented / pending / flag

Manager: "The updates were missing on the last two Tuesdays. What ¹ _____ sending them?"

Engineer: "I waited for a full answer. Next time I will ² _____ the unresolved item."

Manager: "The next update ³ _____ Tuesday at 2 p.m."

Engineer: "Understood. I will report what is confirmed and what is still ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / COVER THIS STRIP UNTIL YOU FINISH

1. prevented | 2. flag | 3. remains due | 4. pending

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-8 and underline the two observed events and their impact. Compare your markings with the facts on the briefing page.
2. Switch roles for turns 9-20. Read the Wednesday trigger and Thursday deadline exactly as printed.
3. Complete the engineer exchange. Read it aloud twice; do not insert a claim about the engineer's attitude.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles aloud. Pause for two seconds at the change of speaker. For the final repeat, cover the bank but keep the case facts and dialogue visible. Restore any missed expression from the answer strip; do not invent replacement facts.

One report, two different purposes

A Read the situation

Negotiate a reporting interface, translate local constraints, and define exceptions without weakening oversight.

Headquarters asks the branch to re-enter eighteen figures into a daily spreadsheet. Most figures are already in the shared dashboard, and re-entry takes one hour each day. Ren needs early warning of service failures, not a second archive of every figure. Both offices can agree the format and reporting cadence for this internal process. They cannot change any separate mandatory reporting requirement.

07

PEOPLE / Nadia: International manager of a US branch | Ren: Headquarters operations manager

TRANSLATE THE BUSINESS NEED

Headquarters may experience fewer updates as loss of visibility; a branch may experience repeated requests as distrust. Neither interpretation is established by the request alone. Ask what decision the information supports, then propose a format that serves it. Explain the local workload in measurable terms. Avoid describing one office as "bureaucratic" or the other as "uncooperative" when the real disagreement concerns frequency, evidence, and responsibility.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use only the briefing. Explanations: page 67.

1. What does headquarters primarily need?

- A A second archive of every figure
- C Early warning of service failures

- B A list of staff nationalities
- D A different office name

2. What is the known cost of daily re-entry?

- A One hour each day
- C One hour each month

- B Eighteen hours each day
- D No time at all

3. What must remain outside this negotiation?

- A The internal spreadsheet layout
- C The shared dashboard link

- B Separate mandatory reporting requirements
- D Who sends the internal update

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words

Read the meaning, then say the word combination aloud. The combinations show how the term naturally fits into workplace language.

reporting cadence

How often a report or update is provided.

IN USE agree a reporting cadence

exception reporting

Reporting deviations from agreed conditions rather than every routine item.

IN USE use exception reporting

threshold

A defined point that triggers attention or action.

IN USE set an alert threshold

single source of truth

The agreed authoritative record for a particular set of information.

IN USE maintain a single source of truth

duplicate entry

Recording the same information again in another place.

IN USE eliminate duplicate entry

audit trail

A record that shows changes, actions, or supporting evidence.

IN USE preserve an audit trail

visibility

Access to information needed to understand a situation.

IN USE maintain visibility

local context

Conditions specific to the branch or operating environment.

IN USE explain the local context

handoff

Transfer of information or responsibility between people or teams.

IN USE clarify the handoff

service level

An agreed or defined standard of service performance.

IN USE monitor the service level

reporting burden

The time and effort required to prepare and maintain reports.

IN USE reduce the reporting burden

escalation path

The agreed route for bringing an issue to the right authority.

IN USE follow the escalation path

Precision check

An exception is an event outside a defined condition, not anything someone dislikes. A threshold triggers an action; a cadence sets its rhythm. An audit trail preserves the history rather than replacing it with the latest number.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language

Read each complete phrase. The small label names its job in the conversation; the wording remains professional without hiding the point.

ASK ABOUT USE

"Which decision does each daily figure support?"

QUANTIFY THE BURDEN

"Re-entering the eighteen figures takes one hour each day."

PRESERVE THE PURPOSE

"I want to reduce duplication, not reduce your visibility."

OFFER A REPORTING DESIGN

"Could we use the dashboard for routine figures and a separate alert for exceptions?"

DEFINE AN EXCEPTION

"An exception means a missed service target or an unassigned urgent case."

PROTECT AUTHORITY

"This proposal does not change any separate mandatory report."

AGREE A HANDOFF

"The branch duty lead will send the alert and name the action owner."

TEST THE ARRANGEMENT

"Let us trial the format for two weeks and review missed alerts and preparation time."

Not X, but Y

"Not less visibility, but less duplicate entry" distinguishes the business goal from the proposed method.

Unless + condition

"No separate alert is needed unless the threshold is crossed" sets a condition. It does not mean that routine monitoring stops.

Define before using jargon

Explain "exception reporting" with the actual trigger. Without a trigger, people may use the same term for different practices.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which question discovers the business purpose of the report?

- A Why is headquarters so controlling?
- B Which decisions require these daily figures?
- C Who dislikes the branch?
- D Can we stop all reports permanently?

2. Which proposal preserves routine access while reducing re-entry?

- A Remove the dashboard and send no reports.
- B Hide unfavorable results in a private file.
- C Keep the dashboard and send defined exception alerts.
- D Re-enter each figure three times.

3. Which trigger is operationally precise?

- A When things feel serious
- B Whenever someone seems worried
- C At some point after a problem
- D When a service target is missed or an urgent case has no owner

4. Choose the correct meaning of "unless" here: "Send an alert unless the issue is already logged with an owner."

- A The logged-and-owned condition is an exception to sending a new alert.
- B Never monitor a logged issue.
- C An owner is not needed.
- D Every alert is automatically approved.

CHECK, CORRECT, REPEAT

Check the explanations on page 67. For each error, read the complete corrected message aloud once. Then reread the relevant phrase on page 49. All four checks must be corrected before you continue.



One report, two different purposes

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. The small raised number identifies the gap, not the turn. Cover the answer strip on the next page.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

audit trail / single source of truth / reporting burden / visibility / escalation path / handoff / waiver / duplicate entry / cadence / threshold

07

- 01 **Ren:** We need the eighteen branch figures in the daily spreadsheet. When they arrive late, headquarters has less confidence that it can spot a service problem quickly.
- 02 **Nadia:** I understand the need for ¹ _____. May I ask which decision each figure supports? Most of them are already in the shared dashboard.
- 03 **Ren:** The urgent need is to see a missed service target before it becomes a larger problem. The spreadsheet grew over time because different people requested extra columns.
- 04 **Nadia:** That explains the purpose. The current ² _____ takes one hour every day. I would like to remove the repeated work without hiding any figures.
- 05 **Ren:** If we stop receiving the spreadsheet, how will we know whether the dashboard has changed? We cannot watch every branch screen continuously.
- 06 **Nadia:** We could keep the dashboard as the ³ _____ and add a short alert when an agreed condition changes. The alert would link to the actual record.
- 07 **Ren:** I could support that if "exception" has a specific meaning. One branch might alert us about a minor delay, while another waits until a target is missed.
- 08 **Nadia:** Then let us define the ⁴ _____.: a missed service target or an urgent case without an assigned owner. Those are the events this internal alert will cover.
- 09 **Ren:** Who will send the alert? I want to avoid a situation in which the analyst assumes the manager has done it and the manager assumes the opposite.
- 10 **Nadia:** The branch duty lead will own the ⁵ _____. The alert will identify the issue, its current owner, and the next update time. A deputy will cover absence.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the same bank from the previous page. Finish all ten gaps before uncovering the numbered answer strip below.

- 11 **Ren:** That is clearer. What about changes to the figures after the first alert? We sometimes need to reconstruct what the team knew at a particular time.
- 12 **Nadia:** We will preserve an ⁶ _____ in the shared record. The alert will not replace the underlying data or erase earlier values.
- 13 **Ren:** Then a daily exception check and a weekly summary could work. I do not need eighteen manually copied figures when nothing has changed.
- 14 **Nadia:** Let us record that ⁷ _____ explicitly: monitor daily, alert on the defined events, and summarize weekly. A quiet day does not mean monitoring has stopped.
- 15 **Ren:** Agreed, but some reports serve other requirements. I cannot authorize the branch to stop those as part of this conversation.
- 16 **Nadia:** Nor am I asking you to. This is a change to an internal reporting process, not a ⁸ _____ of any separate mandatory requirement.
- 17 **Ren:** Let us trial the arrangement for two weeks. We should compare the time spent preparing updates and check whether any relevant alert was missed.
- 18 **Nadia:** I will record those as the trial criteria. The aim is a lower ⁹ _____ with no loss of the agreed warning function.
- 19 **Ren:** If an alert has no response, send it to me and the duty manager instead of copying everyone. I will make sure the receiving side knows its responsibility.
- 20 **Nadia:** Then we have an ¹⁰ _____ as well as a reporting format. I will send the one-page agreement, and we will confirm the named owners before the trial starts.

07

ANSWERS / COVER THIS STRIP UNTIL YOU FINISH

1. visibility | 2. duplicate entry | 3. single source of truth | 4. threshold | 5. handoff | 6. audit trail | 7. cadence | 8. waiver | 9. reporting burden | 10. escalation path

A repeated staffing spreadsheet

F Say it

A shared roster already lists confirmed shifts. The office needs a separate alert only when a shift remains unfilled at the agreed checkpoint. Employment and safety requirements remain unchanged.

Complete the four short exchanges using the bank. Each entry is used once. Read the completed conversation aloud; then check the answer strip.

07

WORD + PHRASE BANK

duplication / record / handoff / alert

Ren: "Keep the roster as the authoritative ¹ _____."

Nadia: "At the checkpoint, an unfilled shift triggers an ² _____."

Ren: "This change reduces ³ _____, not required safeguards."

Nadia: "We will name an owner and a deputy for the ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / COVER THIS STRIP UNTIL YOU FINISH

1. record | 2. alert | 3. duplication | 4. handoff

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read the dialogue with Nadia and Ren as equal partners in designing this internal process, not as national stereotypes.
2. Switch roles for turns 7-16. Read the alert threshold, cadence, and limits without dropping any condition.
3. Complete and read the staffing exchange. End by repeating exactly what the new arrangement does not change.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles aloud. Pause for two seconds at the change of speaker. For the final repeat, cover the bank but keep the case facts and dialogue visible. Restore any missed expression from the answer strip; do not invent replacement facts.

An apology that changes the next meeting

A Read the situation

Acknowledge a specific impact, separate intent from effect, repair the record, and agree a verifiable change.

Daniel interrupted Lena twice while she explained a customer risk. He then summarized her concern as a timing preference, which was inaccurate. Lena later said she felt dismissed. The risk itself remains unresolved. Daniel wants to repair the interaction and correct the meeting record without making an empty promise that the project decision will go Lena's way.

PEOPLE / Daniel: International project manager | Lena: US-based risk analyst

08

AN EXPLANATION IS NOT AN ERASER

"I was trying to keep us on time" can explain an intention, but it does not undo an interruption or an inaccurate record. Start with what you did and the effect reported by the other person. Then state a concrete repair. The person receiving the apology does not owe instant reassurance. Disagreement about the project may remain after the relationship improves. A useful repair changes the process without promising a predetermined business decision.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use only the briefing. Explanations: page 68.

1. What must Daniel correct in the record?

- | | |
|---|---|
| A The office address | B The inaccurate description of Lena's concern |
| C Every project date automatically | D Lena's name |

2. What can a sincere repair legitimately promise?

- | | |
|---|--|
| A Lena will win every future decision. | B No one will disagree again. |
| C A corrected record and a protected turn to explain the risk. | D The risk is already resolved. |

3. What remains open after an apology?

- | | |
|--|---|
| A The actual customer risk | B Whether Daniel interrupted twice |
| C Whether Lena raised a concern | D Whether a meeting occurred |

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words

Read the meaning, then say the word combination aloud. The combinations show how the term naturally fits into workplace language.

acknowledge

Recognize an action, fact, or experience explicitly.

IN USE acknowledge the impact

intent

What someone meant or hoped to accomplish.

IN USE explain an intent

impact

What an action actually did or how it affected someone.

IN USE separate intent from impact

defensiveness

Responding mainly to protect oneself from criticism.

IN USE reduce defensiveness

repair

An action that addresses a communication or relationship failure.

IN USE make a concrete repair

retraction

Withdrawal of a statement that should no longer stand.

IN USE issue a retraction

correction

A change that makes a record or statement accurate.

IN USE circulate a correction

mischaracterize

Describe someone's position inaccurately or unfairly.

IN USE mischaracterize a concern

good faith

An honest effort to engage rather than mislead or obstruct.

IN USE act in good faith

commitment

An undertaking to do something specific.

IN USE make a limited commitment

follow-up

Later action to check or continue an agreed step.

IN USE set a follow-up

working agreement

Explicit expectations for how people will cooperate.

IN USE establish a working agreement

Precision check

An explanation describes why something happened; it does not automatically excuse the impact. A correction replaces inaccurate information, while a retraction withdraws a statement. Follow-up checks progress; follow-through carries out the promise.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language

Read each complete phrase. The small label names its job in the conversation; the wording remains professional without hiding the point.

OWN THE ACTION

"I interrupted you twice and summarized your concern inaccurately."

APOLOGIZE DIRECTLY

"I am sorry I cut you off."

ACKNOWLEDGE THE EFFECT

"You did not get a fair chance to explain the customer risk."

EXPLAIN WITHOUT EXCUSING

"I was trying to manage time; that does not justify misrepresenting your point."

CORRECT THE RECORD

"I will send a correction to everyone who received the original summary."

MAKE A PROCESS COMMITMENT

"You will have an uninterrupted turn before we decide."

AVOID A FALSE OUTCOME PROMISE

"I cannot promise agreement, but I can promise an accurate review."

CHECK THE REPAIR

"After the next meeting, we will check whether the new turn-taking rule was followed."

Own the subject

"I interrupted you" names the actor. "Interruptions happened" removes that responsibility from the sentence.

Avoid conditional apologies

"I am sorry if you felt dismissed" makes the reported impact sound doubtful. "I am sorry I cut you off" owns a specific action.

Process versus outcome

"We will review the risk accurately" is a process commitment. "Your recommendation will be approved" promises a result before the review.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Choose the apology that owns a specific action.

- A I am sorry you misunderstood my style.
- B Mistakes may have happened somehow.
- C I am sorry if anyone was sensitive.
- D I am sorry I interrupted you twice.

2. Which sentence explains intent without using it as an excuse?

- A I meant well, so there is no problem.
- B I wanted to save time; I still should not have cut you off.
- C My intent cancels the impact.
- D You should have known what I meant.

3. Which commitment is within Daniel's control?

- A Everyone will agree with Lena.
- B The risk cannot recur.
- C I will circulate the correction to the original recipients.
- D The client will accept any proposal.

4. What does restoring trust require here beyond an apology?

- A An accurate record and observable follow-through
- B Immediate forgiveness from Lena
- C A promise never to discuss risk
- D Removal of all disagreement

CHECK, CORRECT, REPEAT

Check the explanations on page 68. For each error, read the complete corrected message aloud once. Then reread the relevant phrase on page 56. All four checks must be corrected before you continue.

An apology that changes the next meeting

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. The small raised number identifies the gap, not the turn. Cover the answer strip on the next page.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

working agreement / correction / good faith / mischaracterized / on the record / agreement / follow-up / intent / follow through / repair

08

- 01 **Daniel:** Thank you for meeting with me. Yesterday I interrupted you twice, then described your customer-risk concern as a preference about timing. That description was not accurate.
- 02 **Lena:** It was not. I needed to explain the consequence for the customer, but the summary¹ _____ my concern as a personal preference.
- 03 **Daniel:** I am sorry I cut you off. I was trying to keep the meeting on time, but that does not justify interrupting you or getting the point wrong.
- 04 **Lena:** I can accept that saving time was your² _____. The effect was that the group moved on before hearing the risk, and I did not know how to reopen it.
- 05 **Daniel:** That matters. I will send a correction to everyone who received the summary. It will state that you raised an unresolved customer risk, not merely a timing preference.
- 06 **Lena:** Please make that a visible³ _____, not a quiet edit. Otherwise people who already read the original may continue using the wrong version.
- 07 **Daniel:** Agreed. I will label the correction and link it to the original note. I can also put the risk back on the agenda before the project decision.
- 08 **Lena:** That would be a useful⁴ _____. I am not asking you to accept my recommendation automatically; I need the evidence to be heard accurately.
- 09 **Daniel:** At the next meeting, you will have an uninterrupted turn to explain the risk and your proposed response. I will summarize it and ask you to check my wording.
- 10 **Lena:** Then we can separate fair consideration from⁵ _____. I may still disagree with the final decision, but at least the group will be deciding on the actual issue.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the same bank from the previous page. Finish all ten gaps before uncovering the numbered answer strip below.

- 11 **Daniel:** Yes. I cannot promise the outcome, but I can promise an accurate review. I also want you to be able to say "I have not finished" if I interrupt again.
- 12 **Lena:** I can use that phrase. It will help if the ⁶ _____ applies to everyone, not just to me after this conversation.
- 13 **Daniel:** It will. I will introduce a rule that speakers finish the relevant point before another person responds, except when an urgent safety issue requires immediate interruption.
- 14 **Lena:** Thank you. I do not need a long explanation of why yesterday happened. I need you to ⁷ _____ when the next meeting becomes hurried.
- 15 **Daniel:** That is reasonable. Let us have a five-minute check after the meeting to review whether the rule was followed and whether the risk was recorded correctly.
- 16 **Lena:** That five-minute ⁸ _____ gives us a chance to check what actually happened. I may still need time to feel comfortable raising a difficult point, even if the next meeting goes better.
- 17 **Daniel:** I understand. You do not need to reassure me today. I will make the correction first and demonstrate the change, rather than ask you to say the problem is over.
- 18 **Lena:** I appreciate that. I am willing to continue in ⁹ _____, while keeping the customer risk on the table until the group has reviewed it.
- 19 **Daniel:** Then I will send the corrected note today and give you the agenda slot before the decision. Please check the factual wording when it arrives.
- 20 **Lena:** I will. Let us put those steps ¹⁰ _____: a visible correction, an uninterrupted explanation, and a check afterward. That is more useful than a promise that we will never disagree.

08

ANSWERS / COVER THIS STRIP UNTIL YOU FINISH

1. mischaracterized | 2. intent | 3. correction | 4. repair | 5. agreement | 6. working agreement | 7. follow through | 8. follow-up | 9. good faith | 10. on the record

Restoring credit for an idea

F Say it

Daniel presented Lena's process idea without naming her contribution. The audience may now think it was his idea. He can correct the attribution in the same project channel.

Complete the four short exchanges using the bank. Each entry is used once. Read the completed conversation aloud; then check the answer strip.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

commitment / acknowledging / omission / attribution

08

Daniel: "I presented your idea without ¹ _____ your contribution."

Lena: "Please correct the ² _____ in the same project channel."

Daniel: "I will name your contribution explicitly and link to your original note. That is my ³ _____."

Lena: "Thank you. I will check the corrected note; that does not mean the original ⁴ _____ did not matter."

ANSWERS / COVER THIS STRIP UNTIL YOU FINISH

1. acknowledging | 2. attribution | 3. commitment | 4. omission

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-8, emphasizing the action Daniel owns and the visible correction he promises. Do not add "if you were offended."
2. Switch roles for turns 9-20. Keep the distinction between an accurate review and a guaranteed outcome.
3. Complete the attribution exchange and read it twice. Finish by naming the concrete promised action, using only the printed facts.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles aloud. Pause for two seconds at the change of speaker. For the final repeat, cover the bank but keep the case facts and dialogue visible. Restore any missed expression from the answer strip; do not invent replacement facts.

01 Why these answers fit

Check meaning before assuming agreement

A Briefing checks

1 B. The briefing confirms six trained people; the additional two are not yet confirmed.

2 C. Aiko owns this decision. Jordan supplies the staffing information.

3 A. The problem is the scope of the apparent agreement, not message delivery.

D Language checks

1 C. Authorization is permission to act; receiving or reading the plan does not provide it.

2 B. An embedded question uses subject + verb: "the date is final."

3 D. The final staffing level is unknown, so the record must preserve the condition.

4 A. A dependency is resolved when the required condition or preceding work is settled.

F Transfer conversation

1 positive feedback on the demonstration. The team evaluated a demonstration; neither review nor purchase is complete.

2 subject to. "Subject to" makes review a condition, not something to bypass.

3 approval authority. The question asks who is entitled to approve the purchase.

4 constitute. "Constitute" means count as. Feedback may precede approval, but does not itself amount to approval.

E Dialogue gaps

1 green light. Turn 2. Giving the green light means allowing an action to proceed. The printed "the" completes the phrase. Jordan supported the sequence but did not approve Monday.

2 conditional. Turn 4. Support depends on having eight trained people. Jordan accepts the approach only if that condition is met.

3 unconfirmed. Turn 6. A scheduled assessment does not establish extra capacity. Its outcome remains unknown.

4 certify. Turn 8. Jordan can obtain or discuss results but cannot formally attest to them. The sentence limits authority, not communication.

5 flag. Turn 10. To flag an item is to draw attention to it. Jordan cannot approve or resolve a missing result, and should not minimize it.

6 acknowledgment. Turn 12. "Understood" can acknowledge a message without approving it. The minutes need to preserve that distinction.

7 reservation. Turn 14. Having a reservation means having a concern or qualification. It need not mean rejecting the whole plan.

8 read-back. Turn 16. Aiko restates the agreement for confirmation. She is not predicting an outcome, referring a dispute upward, or removing a requirement.

9 authorization. Turn 18. Authorization is permission to act. Jordan can check the wording; only Aiko can authorize the launch after the staffing check.

10 still provisional. Turn 20. The date remains conditional. None of the evidence makes it final, irrelevant, or guaranteed.

02 Why these answers fit

Challenge ideas respectfully

A Briefing checks

- 1 C.** The trial used four hours, which challenges the two-hour estimate.
- 2 B.** The briefing gives Mei discretion over account count, not additional staffing.
- 3 A.** A specific evidence request tests the proposal without inventing a personal motive.

D Language checks

- 1 B.** The response accepts the evidence while leaving the account count open to revision.
- 2 D.** "Indicates" signals evidence of risk without claiming certainty.
- 3 C.** It protects people while allowing substantive disagreement.
- 4 A.** It asks for a feasible alternative using the staff actually available.

F Transfer conversation

- 1 confirmations.** A claim of confirmed renewals needs customer confirmations.
- 2 can substantiate.** "Substantiate" means support with evidence; seven is the supported figure.
- 3 possible.** The three renewals are possibilities, not established commitments.
- 4 assumption.** The disagreement concerns the estimate and its basis, not a personal characteristic.

E Dialogue gaps

- 1 premise.** Turn 2. A premise is a starting assumption. Mei asks which assumption in the plan Chris is challenging.
- 2 evidence gap.** Turn 4. The estimate lacks supporting evidence. Neither approval nor extra staffing has been established, and motives remain unknown.
- 3 concede.** Turn 6. Mei accepts the template point. She does not reject, ignore, or delay that acknowledgment.
- 4 scrutiny.** Turn 8. Scrutiny means close examination of the work. Mei welcomes that examination while setting a boundary around personal judgments.
- 5 impact.** Turn 10. The focus is how the wording affected others, not a legal judgment or a vote on the wording.
- 6 counterproposal.** Turn 12. Chris offers an alternative design. He neither grants approval nor demands unconditional compliance.
- 7 validate.** Turn 14. The smaller sample cannot establish that a full rollout is justified. It may precede or inform a later decision.
- 8 non-negotiable.** Turn 16. Two managers is a fixed constraint for this decision. The account count and review points can still change.
- 9 retain.** Turn 18. The team can keep a substantive disagreement while correcting the personal remark. It need not hide or resolve the design issue immediately.
- 10 stress-test.** Turn 20. The revised pilot will examine the assumption under real workload. Announcing an estimate does not test it.

03 Why these answers fit

Make authority and participation clear

A Briefing checks

- 1 C.** Only internal task order is within the stated delegation.
- 2 B.** The briefing identifies these two approval boundaries.
- 3 D.** The trial has a defined two-week period, after which the process can be reviewed.

D Language checks

- 1 D.** It names both the delegated area and the reserved decision.
- 2 B.** "Must" expresses the compulsory notification stated in the question.
- 3 A.** Supplying input is consultation; the other choices exercise decision authority.
- 4 C.** Participation and disagreement do not remove the assigned decision owner.

F Transfer conversation

- 1 may.** "May" grants the specific permission described.
- 2 seek your approval.** A higher cost is outside the delegation, so approval must come before booking.
- 3 my decision.** Sofia expressly reserves the date decision.
- 4 approval boundary.** The boundary explains which decisions need Sofia's approval.

E Dialogue gaps

- 1 decision rights.** Turn 2. The missing information is who may decide which matters.
- 2 delegated.** Turn 4. Sofia grants Alex authority for a defined period and scope.
- 3 remit.** Turn 6. A remit is an assigned area of authority or work.
- 4 exception.** Turn 8. A purchase falls outside the normal permission granted here.
- 5 consulted.** Turn 10. Support provides input; Alex remains the decision owner for the internal sequence.
- 6 discretion.** Turn 12. Discretion is the freedom to choose within the agreed limits.
- 7 accountability.** Turn 14. Sofia keeps responsibility for oversight and support while Alex coordinates the work.
- 8 responsibilities.** Turn 16. Knowing the actual duties matters more than memorizing the letters in a role map.
- 9 escalation threshold.** Turn 18. The threshold identifies when Alex must take a proposed decision back to Sofia.
- 10 review.** Turn 20. The two-week checkpoint evaluates the trial; it does not automatically approve continuation.

04 Why these answers fit

Negotiate realistic commitments

A Briefing checks

- 1 B.** The Friday deliverable is an estimate, not verified data.
- 2 C.** Choosing an option does not make the missing check complete sooner.
- 3 D.** It supplies a day, a clock time, and the location defining that time.

D Language checks

- 1 C.** Only the labeled Friday estimate matches the stated capacity.
- 2 A.** Use present simple in this conditional clause: "If you choose."
- 3 B.** It states both the limitation and the outstanding check.
- 4 D.** The needed decision helps determine whether an estimate can serve the meeting.

F Transfer conversation

- 1 internal.** An internal draft is available; external release must wait for review.
- 2 until.** "Not until" states the condition that must be met before release.
- 3 review pending.** The label accurately preserves the outstanding review.
- 4 finishes.** The future condition takes present simple: "finishes."

E Dialogue gaps

- 1 deliverable.** Turn 2. The distinction is between two outputs: an estimate and a verified report.
- 2 reconciliation.** Turn 4. Comparing supplier records and resolving differences is reconciliation.
- 3 caveat.** Turn 6. The estimate needs a stated limitation, not an assurance that it is final.
- 4 provisional.** Turn 8. The visible label must show that the figure is not yet final.
- 5 provided that.** Turn 10. The delivery promise depends on unchanged scope; this phrase states that condition.
- 6 scope creep.** Turn 12. Adding two branches would expand the agreed work after the deadline was set.
- 7 commit.** Turn 14. "Commit to" names the undertaking Omar can make: explaining a difference.
- 8 trade-off.** Turn 16. The team exchanges early availability for provisional rather than verified information.
- 9 contingency.** Turn 18. The fallback is a status update if the expected supplier check is delayed.
- 10 guarantee.** Turn 20. The Friday number must not be understood as an assurance of the eventual result.

05 Why these answers fit

Include every voice in a meeting

A Briefing checks

1 B. Arun posted a concern in chat without receiving a response.

2 C. The check is a stated prerequisite and is not complete.

3 A. The meeting chair also holds the decision authority in this case.

D Language checks

1 C. It preserves Arun's turn and gives Ben a predictable next turn.

2 B. It restates the known information without inferring motive or approval.

3 D. It records status, work ownership, and decision authority accurately.

4 A. Routing is a stated prerequisite; deferring it would bypass the decision condition.

F Transfer conversation

1 the floor. The floor is the chance to speak, not decision authority.

2 pending. The missing prerequisite means approval has not yet been completed.

3 paraphrase. The chair restates the meaning rather than adding a new conclusion.

4 decision log. The log should preserve the outstanding approval condition.

E Dialogue gaps

1 crosstalk. Turn 2. Overlapping voices prevented the remote contribution from being heard.

2 the floor. Turn 4. Ben explicitly gives Arun the opportunity to speak to the group.

3 paraphrase. Turn 6. Leila restates the distinction and asks Arun to verify it.

4 parking lot. Turn 9. The slide layout is deferred; the prerequisite routing issue is not.

5 decision. Turn 12. Leila retains authority to approve the switch.

6 timebox. Turn 14. A short protected period gives Arun space to finish without letting the meeting drift.

7 action items. Turn 16. Ben takes responsibility for two specific follow-up tasks.

8 dissent. Turn 18. Arun opposes final approval today, not the entire project.

9 decision log. Turn 20. This record distinguishes a pending decision from assigned work.

10 asynchronous input. Turn 20. Colleagues can contribute in the shared note without joining the live meeting.

06 Why these answers fit

Give specific, useful feedback

A Briefing checks

- 1 C.** Arrival dates are observable; the other statements infer motives or overgeneralize.
- 2 A.** Only the deferred staffing update is supplied by the case.
- 3 B.** The timing and dependency are known; the reason for lateness is not.

D Language checks

- 1 D.** It names the observed events and the agreed standard without claiming a motive.
- 2 B.** The question leaves the cause open for an evidence-based explanation.
- 3 C.** It specifies both a condition and a time for action.
- 4 A.** Support for the dependency does not remove the analyst's communication responsibility.

F Transfer conversation

- 1 prevented.** The question asks for a cause without assuming a motive.
- 2 flag.** A status update can identify what is unresolved rather than wait for completion.
- 3 remains due.** The conversation has not changed the agreed deadline.
- 4 pending.** "Pending" preserves the distinction between completed and unresolved work.

E Dialogue gaps

- 1 impact.** Turn 2. The delayed staffing update is the operational effect of the late reports.
- 2 upstream input.** Turn 4. The source file is required from an earlier part of the workflow.
- 3 lead time.** Turn 6. An earlier warning would create time for Elena to help before the deadline.
- 4 flagged.** Turn 8. Flagging identifies the missing input and its risk without pretending to have solved it.
- 5 bottleneck.** Turn 10. The late source-file handoff limits the speed of the downstream report.
- 6 corrective.** Turn 12. The adjective completes "corrective action." Both steps address a known problem: the late handoff and the missing warning.
- 7 performance expectation.** Turn 14. Elena states the deadline, warning trigger, and accuracy requirement explicitly.
- 8 check-in.** Turn 16. A brief scheduled review is a check-in, not a new approval process.
- 9 observable behavior.** Turn 18. Arrival times and warning messages can be observed; an attitude label guesses at motive.
- 10 follow-through.** Turn 20. The participants must now carry out the actions they agreed.

07 Why these answers fit

Coordinate across offices

A Briefing checks

1 C. The stated purpose is timely awareness of service problems.

2 A. The case specifies one hour per day; eighteen is the number of figures.

3 B. The participants may redesign this internal process, not waive separate requirements.

D Language checks

1 B. It asks how the data will be used without assuming a motive.

2 C. The dashboard supplies routine visibility; explicit alerts draw attention to deviations.

3 D. It identifies observable conditions rather than a subjective mood.

4 A. "Unless" introduces the condition under which the stated action is not required.

F Transfer conversation

1 record. The roster is the agreed record of confirmed shifts.

2 alert. The defined exception needs an alert, not assumed approval.

3 duplication. The aim is less repeated administration while retaining the safeguards.

4 handoff. Naming a sender and backup makes the information transfer reliable.

E Dialogue gaps

1 visibility. Turn 2. Headquarters needs access to information about branch service performance.

2 duplicate entry. Turn 4. The figures are being manually recorded again even though they are already available.

3 single source of truth. Turn 6. The shared dashboard remains the agreed authoritative record, rather than competing spreadsheets.

4 threshold. Turn 8. The missed target or unassigned urgent case defines when an alert is required.

5 handoff. Turn 10. The duty lead transfers the information with an owner and an update time.

6 audit trail. Turn 12. A history of data and changes lets the offices reconstruct what was known.

7 cadence. Turn 14. Daily monitoring, event-triggered alerts, and weekly summaries define the rhythm of reporting.

8 waiver. Turn 16. A waiver would remove a requirement; this internal redesign does not do that.

9 reporting burden. Turn 18. The trial aims to reduce preparation time while preserving useful information.

10 escalation path. Turn 20. Ren names the route to use when an alert has not received a response.

08 Why these answers fit

Repair misunderstandings and build trust

A Briefing checks

- 1 B.** He described a customer risk as a timing preference.
- 2 C.** Daniel can change the process and record without promising a business outcome.
- 3 A.** Repairing the interaction does not itself resolve the substantive risk.

D Language checks

- 1 D.** The speaker accepts responsibility for an observable action without shifting blame.
- 2 B.** The explanation does not remove responsibility for the interruption.
- 3 C.** He controls his own correction, not everyone's reactions or the client's decisions.
- 4 A.** The repair is demonstrated by actions; it does not require instant forgiveness or agreement.

F Transfer conversation

- 1 acknowledging.** The failure was to recognize Lena's contribution.
- 2 attribution.** Attribution identifies who contributed the idea.
- 3 commitment.** He promises an action within his control.
- 4 omission.** The omission is the failure to name the contribution; a repair does not erase its significance.

E Dialogue gaps

- 1 mischaracterized.** Turn 2. The summary inaccurately turned a customer risk into a personal timing preference.
- 2 intent.** Turn 4. Saving time explains the intended purpose; it does not erase the effect.
- 3 correction.** Turn 6. The original recipients need an explicit accurate replacement, not an unnoticed edit.
- 4 repair.** Turn 8. Correcting the record and reopening the issue address the specific communication failure.
- 5 agreement.** Turn 10. A fair hearing does not require the decision maker to accept the recommendation.
- 6 working agreement.** Turn 12. The turn-taking rule should be an explicit norm for the whole group.
- 7 follow through.** Turn 14. After "need you to," use the verb phrase "follow through." Lena wants Daniel to carry out his promise when time pressure returns.
- 8 follow-up.** Turn 16. The later five-minute check tests whether the repair was put into practice.
- 9 good faith.** Turn 18. Lena offers an honest willingness to continue without claiming instant trust or agreement.
- 10 on the record.** Turn 20. Putting the steps on the record makes the agreed actions explicit and available for later checking.

Find the move you need

Use these as precise language models. Replace details only when you know the actual facts, authority, and agreed conditions.

01 Check meaning before assuming agreement

Specify the reference: When you say "fine," are you referring to the date or the overall approach?

Check a commitment: Can I record that as a commitment, or is it still a possibility?

Close the loop: I will send the revised record and ask you to confirm it.

Full phrase set: page 7 | Extended dialogue: pages 9-10

02 Challenge ideas respectfully

Ask for the premise: Which assumption are you challenging?

Name the distinction: Let us separate the objective from the proposed method.

Close firmly: We will revise the account count and test the workload before expanding.

Full phrase set: page 14 | Extended dialogue: pages 16-17

03 Make authority and participation clear

Invite a recommendation: Bring me your preferred option and the reason for it.

Set a limit: That discretion does not include additional spending.

Schedule review: We will review the trial after two weeks using the agreed criteria.

Full phrase set: page 21 | Extended dialogue: pages 23-24

04 Negotiate realistic commitments

Identify the purpose: What decision does the Friday meeting need to make?

State a firm limit: I cannot commit to verified figures before the reconciliation is complete.

Confirm the choice: Then our agreement is Friday estimates, followed by Monday verification.

Full phrase set: page 28 | Extended dialogue: pages 30-31



Keep the conversation productive

Use these as precise language models. Replace details only when you know the actual facts, authority, and agreed conditions.

05 Include every voice in a meeting

Stop overlap: One voice at a time, please; the remote line cannot distinguish us.

Invite a specific view: Arun, what remains unverified in the routing check?

Close with ownership: The next action belongs to Arun; the go-live decision remains with me.

Full phrase set: page 35 | Extended dialogue: pages 37-38

06 Give specific, useful feedback

Name the occasion: For each of the last two weekly reports, we agreed on Thursday noon.

Ask without assigning motive: What prevented the Thursday delivery?

Define follow-up: We will review the next two reports at a short Friday check-in.

Full phrase set: page 42 | Extended dialogue: pages 44-45

07 Coordinate across offices

Ask about use: Which decision does each daily figure support?

Offer a reporting design: Could we use the dashboard for routine figures and a separate alert for exceptions?

Test the arrangement: Let us trial the format for two weeks and review missed alerts and preparation time.

Full phrase set: page 49 | Extended dialogue: pages 51-52

08 Repair misunderstandings and build trust

Own the action: I interrupted you twice and summarized your concern inaccurately.

Explain without excusing: I was trying to manage time; that does not justify misrepresenting your point.

Check the repair: After the next meeting, we will check whether the new turn-taking rule was followed.

Full phrase set: page 56 | Extended dialogue: pages 58-59

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

accountability retain accountability	20
acknowledge acknowledge the impact	55
acknowledgment acknowledge receipt	6
action item assign an action item	34
asynchronous input collect asynchronous input	34
attribution check an attribution	41
audit trail preserve an audit trail	48
authorization obtain authorization	6
best effort make a best-effort attempt	27
bottleneck remove a bottleneck	41
burden of proof meet the burden of proof	13
capacity constraint work within a capacity constraint	13
caveat include a caveat	27
check-in schedule a check-in	41
commitment make a limited commitment	55
concession make a limited concession	13
conditional agreement record conditional agreement	6
consensus build consensus	20
consultation hold a consultation	20
contingency plan a contingency	27
correction circulate a correction	55
corrective action agree corrective action	41
counterproposal put forward a counterproposal	13
crosstalk reduce crosstalk	34

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

decision log update the decision log	34
decision owner name the decision owner	20
decision rights clarify decision rights	20
defensiveness reduce defensiveness	55
delegation delegate a decision	20
deliverable define the deliverable	27
dependency resolve a dependency	6
devil's advocate play devil's advocate	13
discretion exercise discretion	20
dissent record dissent	34
duplicate entry eliminate duplicate entry	48
endorsement endorse a proposal	6
escalation path follow the escalation path	48
escalation threshold agree an escalation threshold	20
estimate provide an estimate	27
evidence base strengthen the evidence base	13
exception approve an exception	20
exception reporting use exception reporting	48
feasibility assess feasibility	13
follow-through demonstrate follow-through	41
follow-up set a follow-up	55
go/no-go decision make a go/no-go decision	6
good faith act in good faith	55
green light give the green light	6

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

guardrail set clear guardrails	20
handoff clarify the handoff	48
hard deadline meet a hard deadline	27
impact explain the impact	41
impact separate intent from impact	55
intent explain an intent	55
lead time allow sufficient lead time	41
local context explain the local context	48
mischaracterize mischaracterize a concern	55
non-negotiable state a non-negotiable	13
observable behavior describe observable behavior	41
overcommit avoid overcommitting	27
paraphrase paraphrase a concern	34
parking lot put an item in the parking lot	34
pattern identify a pattern	41
performance expectation clarify a performance expectation	41
personal remark avoid personal remarks	13
premise challenge the premise	13
provisional provisional launch date	6
pushback offer constructive pushback	13
quorum confirm a quorum	34
RACI use a RACI matrix	20
read-back give a read-back	6
reconciliation complete the reconciliation	27

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

remit stay within your remit	20
repair make a concrete repair	55
reporting burden reduce the reporting burden	48
reporting cadence agree a reporting cadence	48
reservation express a reservation	6
retraction issue a retraction	55
round-robin use a round-robin	34
SBI use an SBI structure [2]	41
scope clarify the scope	6
scope creep prevent scope creep	27
service level monitor the service level	48
sign-off get final sign-off	6
single source of truth maintain a single source of truth	48
stress-test stress-test an assumption	13
the floor give someone the floor	34
threshold set an alert threshold	48
timebox timebox the discussion	34
trade-off make a trade-off	27
turn-taking manage turn-taking	34
turnaround time agree a turnaround time	27
upstream input obtain upstream input	41
verified verified figures	27
visibility maintain visibility	48
working agreement establish a working agreement	55



Original cases. Clear boundaries.

The scenarios, dialogues, vocabulary explanations, tasks, and answer rationales are original English Ladder teaching material. They are not transcripts of real employees or research interviews. They illustrate language choices, not a universal American communication style.

[1] Council of Europe. Common European Framework of Reference for Languages: mediation resources.

[Open the original source](#)

Used for the broad learning aims of collaborative interaction, clarification, turn-taking, and helping people establish shared meaning. The B2-C1 study range is an editorial choice, not an official endorsement or assessment.

[2] Center for Creative Leadership. Use Situation-Behavior-Impact (SBI) to Understand Intent (2025).

[Open the original source](#)

Informs the distinction between observed behavior, impact, and assumed intent in Lesson 6. SBI is attributed to its originator; the cases and dialogue wording here are original.

[3] Amy Edmondson. Psychological Safety and Learning Behavior in Work Teams (1999). Administrative Science Quarterly, 44(2), 350-383.

[Open the original source](#)

Provides background on interpersonal risk and team learning. The study does not establish national personality types, and this book does not treat its results as rules about individuals.

Publication and reuse

English Ladder | English for Work | Approval draft 01 | 30 September 2026. References checked 30 September 2026. Existing course illustration and ladder mark retained. All fonts are embedded. This approval draft is not yet a replacement for the website's downloadable guides.

For workplace conduct, safety, employment, or legal questions, use the appropriate qualified support and current organizational procedures. Do not treat a successful language exercise as authorization for a real decision.

[Open the matching English Ladder course](#)